

Word family: **harsh / harsher / harshest / harshly / harshness**

Base word: harsh

Comparative: harsher

Superlative: harshest

Related forms: harshly, harshness

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / related adverb and noun forms (相關副詞及名詞)

Your sentence:

> “They seem peaceful, but they also survive long journeys and **harsh natural conditions**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **harsh** means **severe, difficult, and unpleasant to endure**, especially because the natural environment is challenging.

繁體中文： **嚴酷、惡劣、難以承受的，會對人、生物或事物造成很大壓力**

中文翻譯：

> “...they also survive long journeys and **harsh natural conditions**.”

「.....牠們同時又能在漫長旅程和**嚴酷 / 惡劣的自然環境**中生存下來。」

Here:

harsh conditions = 非常艱難、惡劣而需要高度耐受力才能承受的環境條件

1. **harsh = severe / difficult to endure (環境 / 條件) — 嚴酷的；惡劣的**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Very difficult, severe, or unpleasant to live through or withstand.

Practice 1 — Original

> “Sea turtles can survive **harsh natural conditions**.”

「海龜能在**嚴酷的自然環境**中生存。」

Practice 2

> “Few plants can survive the **harsh** desert climate.”

「很少植物能在**惡劣的**沙漠氣候中生存。」

Practice 3

> “The animals face **harsh** winters.”

「這些動物要面對**嚴寒 / 嚴酷的**冬天。」

harsh = 環境、氣候、生活條件等非常艱難，令人或生物難以承受的

Common:

- * harsh conditions
- * harsh climate
- * harsh winter
- * harsh environment
- * harsh reality

2. **harsh** = cruel / excessively strict (人 / 待遇) — 嚴厲的；苛刻的；殘酷的

Harsh can describe treatment, punishment, rules, or a person's behaviour.

Practice 4

> “The punishment seemed unnecessarily **harsh**.”

「這項懲罰似乎過於**嚴厲 / 苛刻**。」

Practice 5

> “He was sometimes too **harsh** with his students.”

「他有時對學生太過**嚴厲**。」

harsh = 對別人過分嚴格、冷酷或缺乏體諒的

This is a major distinct interpersonal sense.

3. **harsh** = severe criticism / unpleasant words (言語) — 尖銳的；嚴厲的；刺耳的

Words, criticism, judgments, or comments can be **harsh**.

Practice 6

> “She received some **harsh** criticism.”

「她受到了一些很**嚴厲 / 尖銳**的批評。」

Practice 7

> “His words were **harsh** but honest.”

「他的話很**尖銳 / 嚴厲**，但很誠實。」

harsh = 言語或批評直接、強烈，令人感到難受或受傷

For strict counting, I would keep this under Meaning 2 because the broader concept is still **severity without softness**.

4. **harsh** = rough / unpleasant to the senses (感官) — 刺耳的；刺眼的；粗糙刺激的

Harsh can describe something unpleasantly strong to the senses.

Practice 8

> “The room was filled with **harsh** white light.”

「房間裡充滿**刺眼的**白光。」

Practice 9

> “The microphone produced a **harsh** sound.”

「麥克風發出了**刺耳的**聲音。」

harsh = 光線、聲音、味道、氣味、質感等強烈得令人不舒服

Common:

- * harsh light
- * harsh sound
- * harsh voice
- * harsh chemicals
- * harsh smell

This is genuinely distinct from harsh weather or harsh punishment.

5. **harsh = damaging / too strong on skin/material (產品 / 物質) — 刺激性強的 ; 傷害性的**

A chemical, soap, cleaning product, or treatment can be **harsh** if it is too strong and may cause damage.

Practice 10

> “This soap is too **harsh** for sensitive skin.”

「這種肥皂對敏感肌膚來說太**刺激 / 太傷皮膚**。」

Practice 11

> “Avoid **harsh** chemicals on the surface.”

「避免在這個表面使用**刺激性過強 / 具腐蝕性的**化學品。」

harsh = 作用過強，可能刺激、磨損或傷害皮膚 / 物料的

This develops from the broader sensory/severe sense.

For core counting, I would usually merge it with Meaning 4.

6. **harsh = ugly / severe-looking (外觀) — 生硬的 ; 強烈不柔和的**

Designs, colours, lines, or features can be described as **harsh** when they look severe or lacking softness.

Practice 12

> “The room had **harsh** lines and cold surfaces.”

「房間的線條很**生硬**，表面也帶冷感。」

Practice 13

> “The lighting made his features look **harsh**.”

「燈光令他的五官看起來很**生硬 / 強烈**。」

****harsh = 外觀、線條或視覺效果缺乏柔和感，顯得強硬或不舒服****

For strict counting, I would place this under the sensory branch.

7. ****harsh = unpleasant reality/fact (抽象) — 殘酷的；嚴峻的****

****Harsh**** can describe facts, truths, or realities that are painful or unpleasant to accept.

Practice 14

> “He had to face the ****harsh reality**** of the situation.”

「他不得不面對情況的****殘酷現實****。」

Practice 15

> “It was a ****harsh truth****, but she needed to hear it.”

「那是一個****殘酷的事實****，但她需要聽到。」

****harsh reality/truth = 令人不舒服、難以接受，但真實而無法逃避的情況 / 事實****

This is a figurative extension of the severe/unpleasant meaning.

Related form: ****harshly****

****Harshly**** means in a severe, cruel, or unpleasant manner.

Practice 16

> “He was ****harshly**** criticized.”

「他受到****嚴厲地****批評。」

Practice 17

> “She spoke ****harshly**** to him.”

「她對他說話非常****嚴厲 / 尖銳****。」

****harshly = 以嚴厲、苛刻、強烈或令人不舒服的方式****

Related form: **harshness**

Harshness means the quality of being harsh.

Practice 18

> “The **harshness** of the climate makes farming difficult.”

「氣候的**嚴酷程度**令耕作很困難。」

Practice 19

> “He regretted the **harshness** of his words.”

「他後悔自己說話太過**尖銳 / 嚴厲**。」

harshness = 嚴酷、嚴厲、刺激或令人難受的性質

It can apply across several branches of **harsh**.

Important distinction: **harsh vs strict**

strict

means requiring rules to be followed closely.

harsh

suggests treatment or rules are **severe, unpleasant, or possibly excessive**.

> a strict teacher

= 嚴格的老師

> a harsh teacher

= 嚴厲甚至苛刻的老師

So **harsh** is usually more negative.

Important distinction: **harsh vs severe**

severe

is a broad formal word meaning very serious, extreme, or intense.

harsh

often adds the idea of:

- * unpleasantness
- * lack of softness
- * difficulty to endure

- > severe injury
- > harsh climate

They overlap, but their typical collocations differ.

Important distinction: **harsh vs cruel**

cruel

means deliberately causing pain or showing no concern for suffering.

harsh

means severe or unpleasant, but does not necessarily imply deliberate cruelty.

A punishment can be harsh without being intentionally cruel.

Important distinction: **harsh vs rough**

rough

can refer to:

- * uneven physical texture
- * violent movement
- * approximate quality
- * difficult conditions

harsh

emphasizes severity or unpleasantness.

> rough surface

> harsh light

> harsh criticism

Different central ideas.

Important distinction: **harsh vs tough**

tough conditions

= difficult and demanding

harsh conditions

= severe, unpleasant, and difficult to endure

They overlap, but **harsh** often emphasizes the environment's severity more strongly.

Important distinction: **harsh vs sharp**

For sound/light:

sharp

often means sudden, piercing, or clearly defined.

harsh

means unpleasantly strong or abrasive.

> sharp sound

= sudden/piercing

> harsh sound

= unpleasant and grating

Important distinction: **harsh vs gentle**

This contrast is especially useful for your sea-turtle passage.

gentle

= soft, mild, kind, not forceful

harsh

= severe, strong, difficult, unpleasant

The turtle has:

> **gentle eyes**

but survives:

> **harsh conditions**

That contrast strengthens the description.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **harsh**

* **harsher**

* **harshes**

* **harshly**

* **harshness**

Useful constructions include:

* harsh conditions

* harsh climate

* harsh punishment

* harsh criticism

* harsh words

* harsh light

* harsh chemicals

* harsh reality

The Golden Manual says figurative and domain uses should be checked broadly, while contexts sharing the same underlying concept should be merged rather than split simply because the noun changes.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
harsh — environment/conditions	氣候、環境或生活條件非常嚴酷、惡劣、難以承受的
harsh — treatment/person	對別人過分嚴厲、苛刻或缺乏體諒的
harsh — criticism/words	言語或批評強烈尖銳、令人難受；與 severe-treatment 義相關
harsh — sensory	聲音、光線、氣味、質感等強烈得令人不舒服的
harsh — chemical/product	作用過強，可能刺激或傷害皮膚 / 物料；與 sensory/severity 義相關
harsh — reality/truth	令人難以接受、痛苦但真實的；殘酷 / 嚴峻
harshly	以嚴厲、苛刻、尖銳或令人不舒服的方式
harshness	嚴酷、嚴厲、刺激或不柔和的性質

For your original sentence

> "...they also survive long journeys and **harsh natural conditions**."

The exact meaning is:

****harsh = 環境非常惡劣、嚴酷，對生物造成很大生存壓力****

So:

> ****harsh natural conditions****

= ****嚴酷 / 惡劣的自然環境條件****

For your database, I would count ****4 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****harsh****:

1. ****severe and difficult to endure — climate, conditions, reality****
2. ****cruel, overly strict, or severe toward people****
3. ****unpleasantly strong to the senses — light, sound, voice, chemicals****
4. ****figuratively painful or difficult to accept — harsh truth/reality****

I would merge ****harsh criticism/words**** into #2, merge ****harsh chemicals/design/light**** into #3, and keep ****harshly / harshness**** as family extensions rather than inflate the core count.